



Ages 14 to 18

Racism, Hate and Standing Up Safely

What racism and faith-targeted abuse look like, what the law says, how to help safely, and where to get support. For all students.

Before You Read This guide covers racism, faith-targeted abuse and hate crime.

This guide is about racism and faith-targeted abuse between young people, including slurs, "jokes", online content and hate crime. It describes racist language but never repeats it. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something that has happened to you or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258, free, 24/7.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students**. It explains what racism and faith-targeted abuse look like, what the law says, how to stand up to it safely, and where to get help.

- Racism can come from anyone, including friends, and be aimed at anyone.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**, and you don't have to deal with it alone.
- If you've been part of it, you can stop, take responsibility and learn.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.

- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone has threatened or hurt you because of who you are, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, any time.

Key Words

Racism

Treating people unfairly or with hostility because of their colour, nationality, or ethnic or national origins. It can be words, actions, exclusion or content.

Faith-targeted abuse

Hostility towards someone because of their religion or belief, including antisemitism and anti-Muslim hatred. It often overlaps with racism.

Prejudice-related incident

What schools often call an incident motivated by prejudice, whether or not it is a crime.

Hate crime

Any crime where the offender shows, or is motivated by, hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity.

Bystander

Someone who sees it happen. Bystanders decide whether racism is laughed at or stopped.

Banter or Racism?

The Difference

- Banter works when everyone is in on it and anyone can say "stop". Jokes about someone's race, religion, accent, name or where they're "from" aren't banter: they single someone out for who they are.
- "It's just a joke", "everyone says it" and "they don't mind" don't change the impact. Schools should never pass abuse off as "banter" or "just having a laugh" (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 193).
- Using a slur "ironically", or because it's in a song or a video, still hurts the person it's aimed at.

- A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before asking for help. One incident is enough.

What It Can Look Like

In Person

- Slurs, racist names or "jokes"; mocking accents, names, hair or food
- "Go back to where you came from", or questions used to make someone feel they don't belong
- Touching someone's hair, or pulling at religious clothing
- Racist gestures, symbols or graffiti; leaving someone out

Online

- Racist memes, stickers, comments or voice chat
- Clips of someone being abused, shared for laughs
- Antisemitic or anti-Muslim conspiracy theories and "jokes"
- Content that treats racism as edgy, funny or "just facts"

What the Law Says

England and Wales

- **Not all racist language is a crime, but some is.** Depending on what was said and done, and the circumstances, it can be a criminal offence to:
- use threatening or abusive words or behaviour that are likely to cause someone harassment, alarm or distress (Public Order Act 1986);
- assault, harass or damage property with racial or religious hostility, which makes the offence "racially or religiously aggravated" (Crime and Disorder Act 1998).

- Any crime can be treated as a hate crime where the offender shows, or is motivated by, hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity (CPS).
- Criminal responsibility in England and Wales starts at 10. The police and courts decide whether a crime has happened, not you, and not school staff.

If you're the one being targeted, you won't be in trouble for asking for help. Your school treats racism as a safeguarding matter as well as a behaviour matter: its job is to keep people safe.

If It Happens to You

What to Do

- **Get to safety**, and go to people you trust. You don't have to answer back.
- **Tell a trusted adult**, the same day if you can. You won't be in trouble for telling.
- **If it's online**: keep it. Don't delete. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help. If you need to block someone now to feel safe, do it, and tell an adult anyway.
- **Look after yourself**. Racism can leave you angry, anxious or exhausted. That's a normal reaction to something wrong. Talk to someone.

It's Not Your Job to Investigate

- You don't have to prove what was said, gather witnesses or monitor what's being posted.
- You don't have to confront anyone, educate them, or meet them to "sort it out". If the school suggests a meeting later, it's your choice, and you can say no.

Online Content and Influence

- Some online content is designed to make racism look funny, rebellious or "just the truth". The more you see, the more normal it can feel.
- Ask: who made this, what do they want me to feel, and who does it hurt?
- Don't share it, even to criticise it. Report it on the platform, and tell an adult if it's being shared in your year group.

- If a friend is getting into content that targets people for their race or religion, or talks about violence, tell a trusted adult. That's looking out for them, not getting them into trouble.

RESPOND: If It's Happening to Someone Else

Racism usually has an audience. Bystanders decide whether it spreads or stops. **You never have to confront anyone.** RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps**, **Pause is the bridge**, and **adults lead the systems steps**.

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)

R Recognise

Notice what's happening.

- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (who's targeted, who's joining in?), **Places** (where does it happen?), **Platforms** (which chats and apps?), **Patterns** (is it repeated, or getting worse?)
- A person laughing along may still be hurting

E Engage

Help, if it is safe to do so.

- The best options are usually to **Delegate** (get an adult, or report it), **Distract** (interrupt, change the subject, or give the person a reason to leave with you) and **Delay** (check in with them afterwards: "That wasn't OK. Are you alright?")
- Saying something directly, like "Not OK", is an option only if you can do it without becoming a target or making it worse. Students who share the targeted person's background may be at more risk: look after yourself too

S Support

Stay close.

- "I'm here. We can talk to someone together."
- Don't ask them to explain or prove it. Keep including them

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Think before you act.

- Three questions: **Risk** (is anyone in danger?), **Rights** (what does the person targeted want?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- **Don't film, share, like or comment:** it spreads the harm
- Don't start a pile-on against the person who said it. You're not expected to investigate or collect evidence

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- Show a different way: don't laugh, don't join in, be kind
- Tell the person help is available, and offer to go with them



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell them what you saw and heard. You don't need to repeat the words: describe them
- It isn't snitching. It's how racism gets stopped



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. Tell them what you saw, and where

Telling an Adult

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.
- You'll be listened to and taken seriously.
- Adults won't make you face the person, and they'll think about how to protect anyone who reported it.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in the plan and the support you get.

If You've Been Part of It

Maybe you used a word you'd heard online, laughed along, or shared a clip. Noticing that is the first step.

- Stop, and don't share it further. Don't delete anything if an adult asks you to keep it.
- Take responsibility. Owning it early is better than being found out.
- There will be consequences, and there will also be a chance to understand the impact and do better.
- If what you've been seeing online, or hearing at home or from friends, is shaping how you think, you can talk about that too. The adult will think carefully about how, and whether, your family is told.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just banter"	Jokes about someone's race or religion single them out for who they are. That's racism.
"It's only racist if you mean it"	Impact matters more than intent. You can hurt someone without meaning to, and still need to put it right.
"You can't be racist if you're from a minority too"	Anyone can say something racist, whatever their background, including towards people from another minority, or their own.
"If they didn't react, it didn't hurt"	People often freeze or laugh it off to get through it.
"Reporting will just make it worse"	Schools are expected to take racism seriously, as a safeguarding matter. Telling is how it gets stopped.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If it happens in your boarding house, tell the house parent on duty, even late. You don't have to wait until morning.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19)**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.** See also Childline: racism and racial bullying.
- **Shout**: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Call Hate Out (Stop Hate UK, for under-18s)**: confidential 24-hour support if you experience or see hate, in the areas Stop Hate UK covers (check at stophateuk.org)
- **Faith-targeted hate**: Tell MAMA (anti-Muslim hate): 0800 456 1226 or report online at tellmamauk.org; confidential, and not a replacement for the police; Community Security Trust (CST) (antisemitism): report online at cst.org.uk/report-incident, or call its 24-hour national number, 0800 032 3263. If you're under 18, it's a good idea to report with a parent or trusted adult.
- **Reporting a hate crime**: True Vision (police online hate crime reporting): report-it.org.uk, or call 101; in an emergency, call 999. An adult can help you do this, or the school can.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Racism, Hate and Standing Up Safely: Student Guide 1 - 14 to 18

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